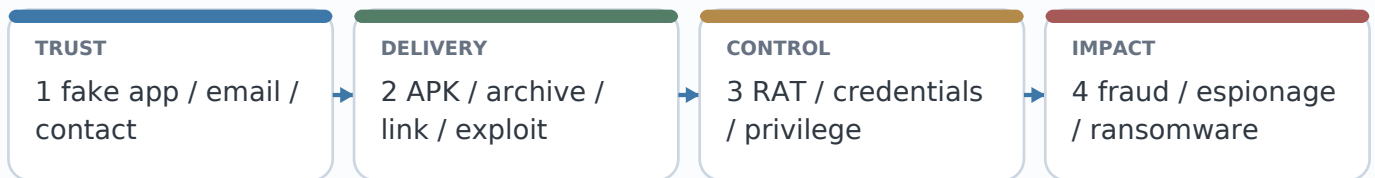


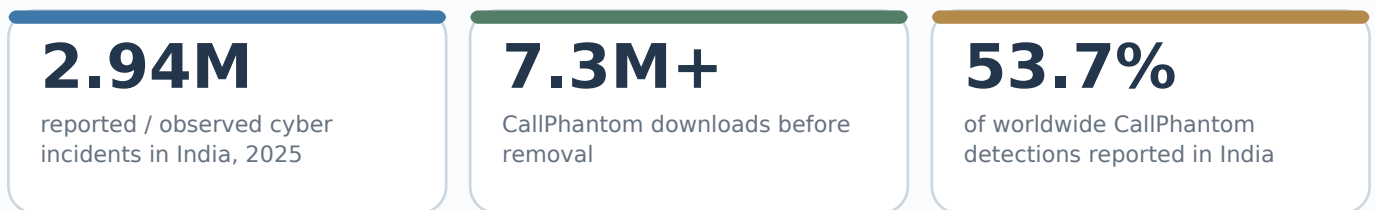
# Cyber Threats Targeting India

Malicious apps, phishing RATs, and exploited vulnerabilities.

**Core finding** Three different doors lead to the same goal: trust creates the opening, malware creates control, and software weakness can turn access into privilege and scale.



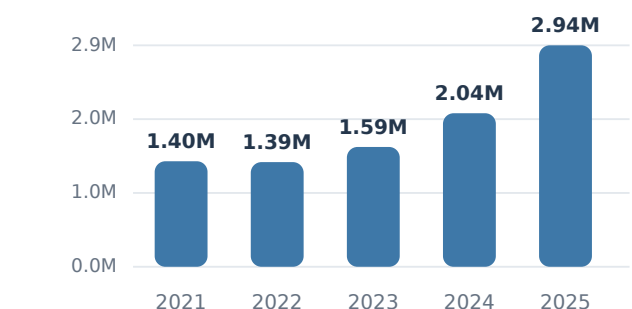
## THREE NUMBERS TO REMEMBER



## 60-SECOND INTERPRETATION

- People are the first doorway. Government, tax, transport, loan and familiar-contact themes make the action feel legitimate.
- Mobile is part of the attack surface. An app can expose messages, notifications, accessibility, credentials and payments.
- A RAT changes the problem. The phishing message is only the start; remote access can persist and expand.
- Known flaws matter too. Patch delay can turn one foothold into wider compromise.

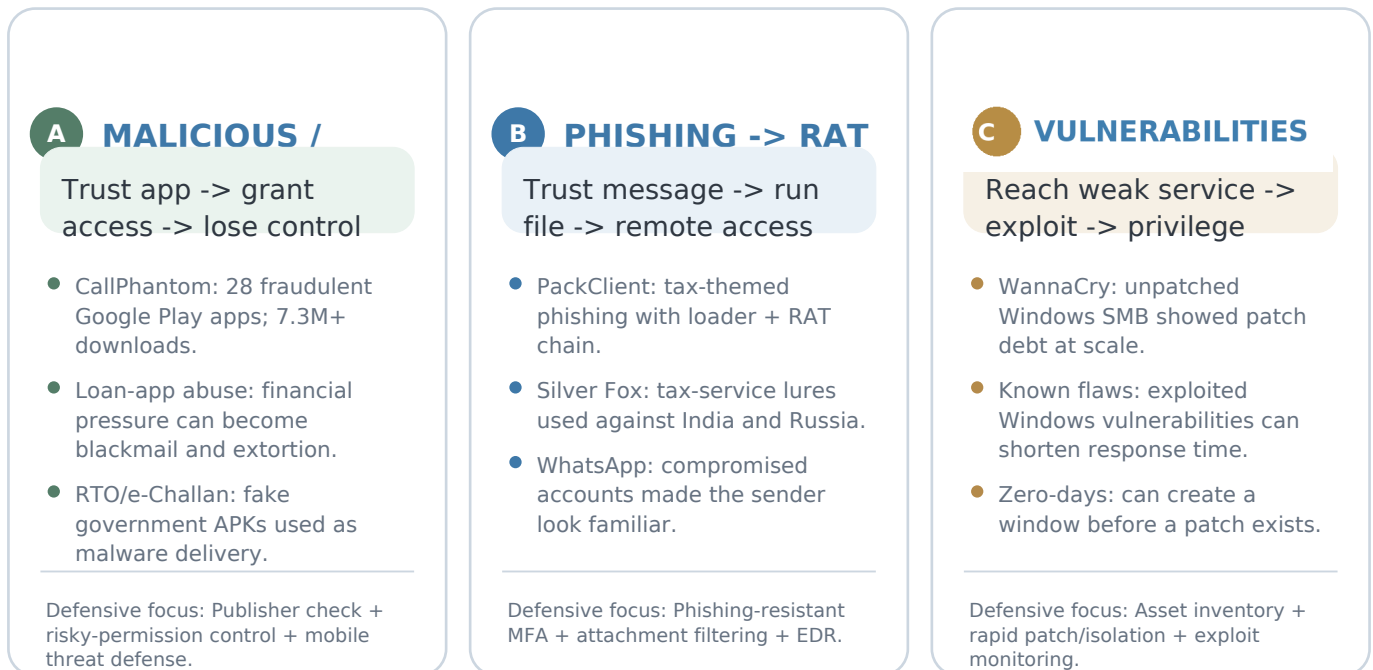
### India incident trend



Reported/observed incidents; not a direct count of successful compromise or loss.

# Three doors. One intrusion.

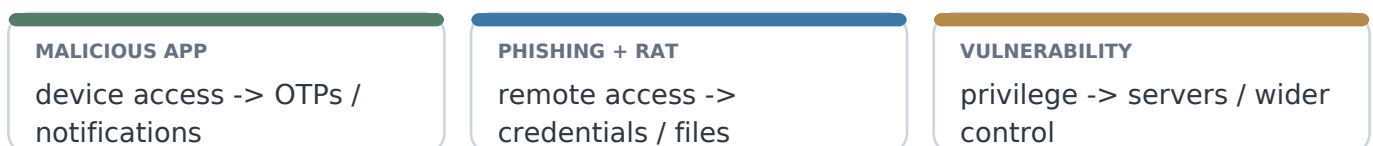
Each category starts differently - but the attacker is trying to reach the same thing: control.



## Plain-language version

A fake app, fake message, or software flaw is just the first step. The goal is to get a foothold, steal something useful, gain more access, and stay there.

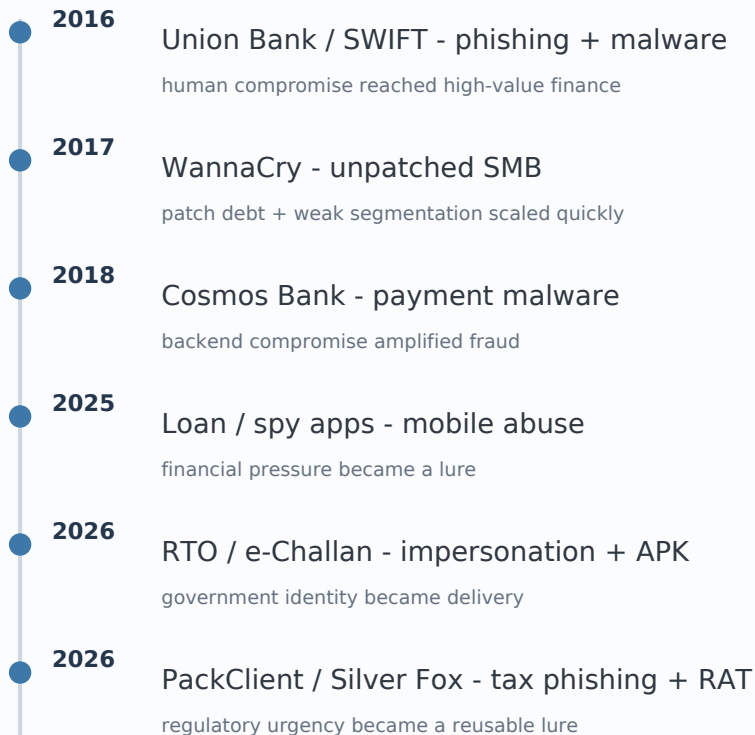
## HOW THE CATEGORIES REINFORCE EACH OTHER



# What changes when these attacks meet India?

Trusted institutions + mobile services + known software weaknesses repeat across the cases.

## HISTORICAL CORRELATION



## EVIDENCE SNAPSHOT

**2.94M**

Reported / observed cyber incidents, India (2025).

**53.7%**

India share of worldwide detections

**CallPhantom**

53.7% of worldwide detections were reported in India.

7.3M+ downloads before removal.

## WHERE THE SAME CHAIN CAN HURT

### FINANCE

transactions, credentials, customer data

### GOVT

tax, transport, citizen services

### HEALTH

availability + sensitive data

### TELCO

identity + downstream phishing

### INDUSTRY

legacy systems + OT exposure

### PEOPLE

device compromise + direct fraud

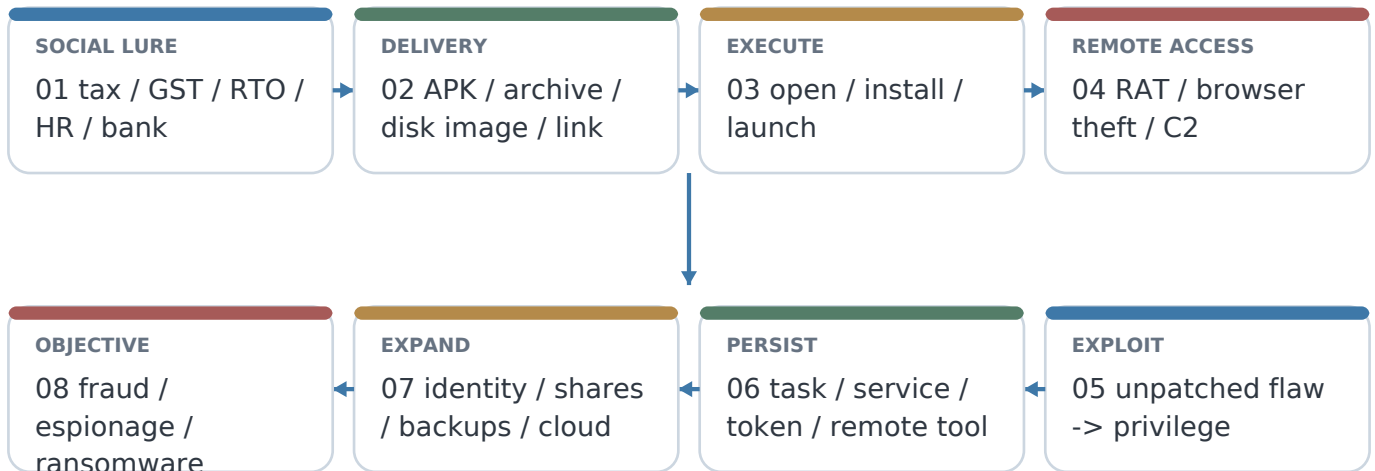
## Interpretation

India is not facing one isolated technique. The cases show a repeatable pattern: attackers borrow trusted identities, use familiar channels, exploit mobile reach, and reuse known technical weaknesses.

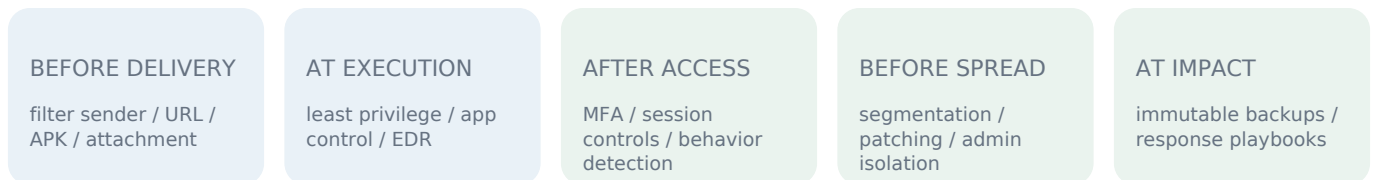
# From one click to enterprise impact

Small first actions can become large compromises when the chain is not broken early.

## THE CENTRAL MODEL OF THE RESEARCH



## WHERE TO BREAK THE CHAIN



## WHY THE CHAIN KEEPS WORKING

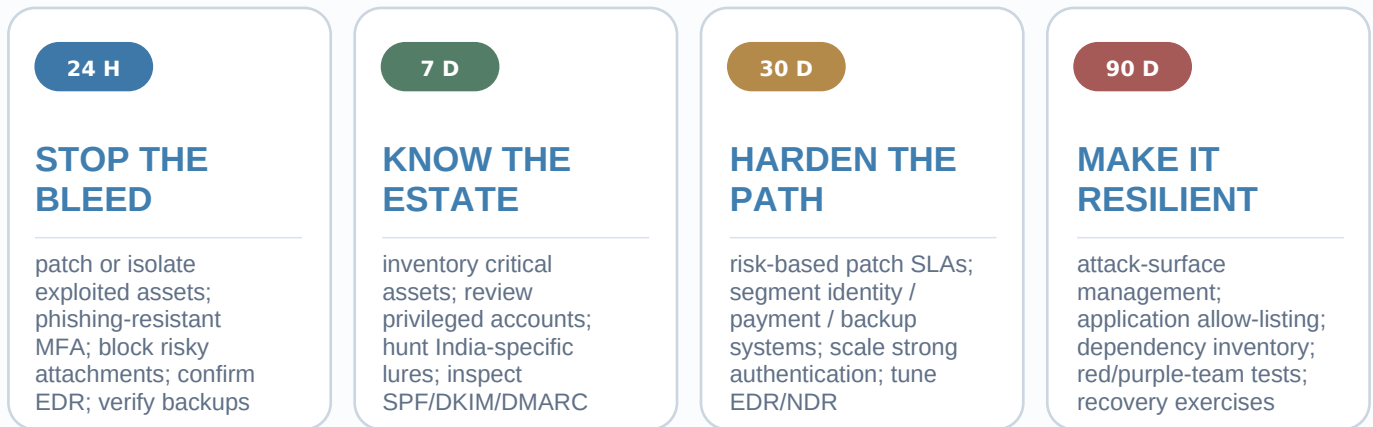


Key idea: defenders do not need to win at every stage. They need enough independent barriers that one successful action cannot become full control.

# A simple defensive plan

Make the first mistake harder, privilege harder to gain, spread harder to achieve, and recovery dependable.

## PRIORITY ROADMAP



## DEFENSIVE ARCHITECTURE - LAYER BY LAYER

|               |                                                                         |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DEVICE        | managed devices + secure configuration + EDR / mobile defense           |
| IDENTITY      | phishing-resistant MFA + least privilege + privileged access management |
| COMMUNICATION | email auth + URL/file analysis + DNS/browser filtering                  |
| NETWORK       | segmentation + restricted admin paths + egress control                  |
| APP / SERVER  | vulnerability management + dependency inventory + exposure monitoring   |
| DETECTION     | central logs + behavioral detections + threat hunting                   |
| RECOVERY      | offline/immutable backups + tested restoration + response runbooks      |

### Bottom line

Do not let one trusted action become full control. Break the chain at delivery, execution, identity, privilege, movement and recovery.

## SELECTED EVIDENCE BASE

- PIB/MHA (24 Mar 2026) - national incident data.
- CERT-In (2017, 2026) - WannaCry; RTO/e-Challan; WhatsApp malware.
- ESET (7 May 2026) - CallPhantom; Kaspersky (30 Apr 2026) - Silver Fox.
- RBI - Union Bank / SWIFT fraud; full reference set preserved in the research paper.